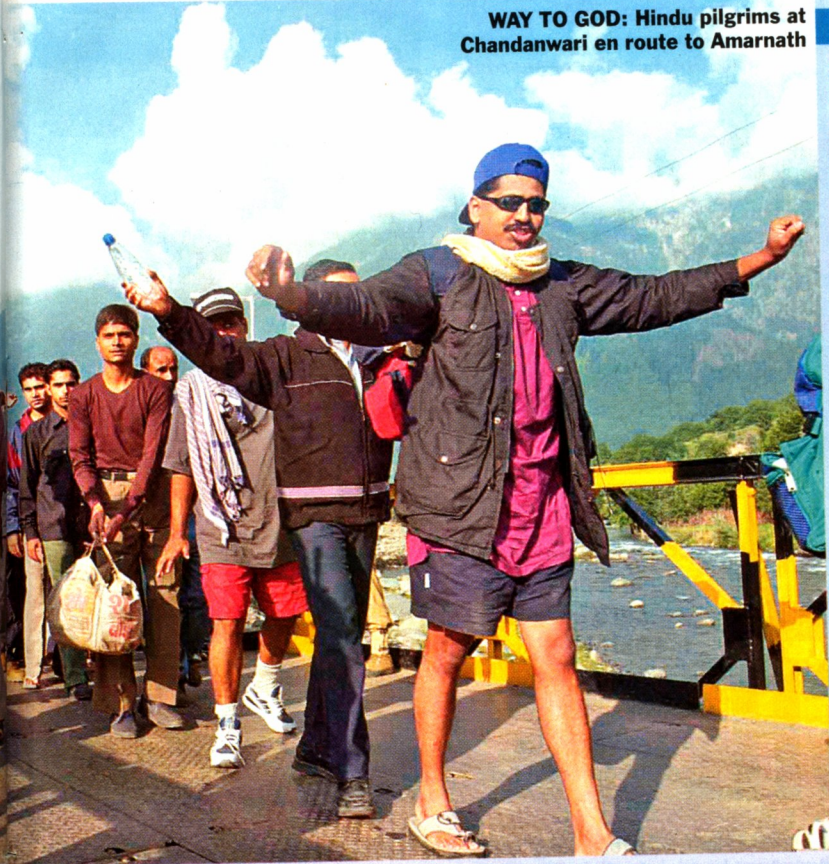


AP PHOTO

WAY TO GOD: Hindu pilgrims at Chandanwari en route to Amarnath



LAND SLIDE

2000: Amarnath Shrine Board constituted. Governor made chairman.

2003: Governor S.K. Sinha asks for foolproof security for pilgrims. Chief Minister Mufti Sayeed ignores the demand.

2005: Sinha asks for land near Baltal to be transferred to ASB. Proposal remains under consideration for three years.

MAY 2008: PDP's forest minister makes recommendation and Chief Minister Ghulam Nabi Azad gives 100 acre land to ASB. Protests in the valley.

JUNE 28, 2008: New Governor N.N. Vohra, now head of ASB, writes to Azad to allow government take charge of pilgrimage logistics and that the Board no more needs land.

JUNE 28, 2008: Coalition partner, PDP, led by Sayeed withdraws its support to the Congress-led government.

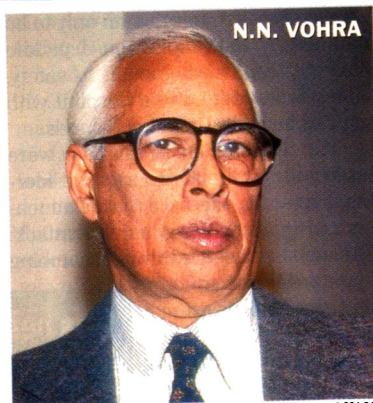
JUNE 29: Azad says government will revoke order. State unit of BJP calls for bandh in Jammu against the revocation.

JULY 1: Government hands over the order after a cabinet meeting; pilgrimage affairs handed over to the State Tourism Department; protests in Kashmir called off, while it turns violent in Jammu.

But within a week of taking over, Vohra made the government rescind the deal.

sembly elections are due by November.

It all began on May 26 when the Congress-led Government, on the insistence of former governor Lieutenant General (retired) S.K. Sinha as chairman of ASB, transferred 100 acre of forest land to the Board to erect facilities for the ever-increasing number of Amarnath pilgrims who visit the cave shrine in Kashmir for two months every year. The land deal was a cabinet decision in which coalition partner PDP was involved and the land transfer was finally carried out at the behest of Forest Minister Qazi Mohammed Afzal, who is a PDP leader. But it slowly snowballed into a controversy for over a month before people in Kashmir began triggering an agitation that quickly transformed into an upsurge for secession from India. Vohra succeeded Sinha as governor of the state on June 25, becoming the first non-military or non-



SIPRA DAS

intelligence governor of the state after 18 years. In a face-saving measure for Congress, the new governor, immediately after taking over, wrote to Azad asking him to let the government take charge of pilgrimage logistics and that the Board no more needs the land.

The final outcome of the contro-

versy so far has not just rejuvenated the separatist camp, but is most likely to provide a strong push for its poll boycott campaign before the elections. In Jammu, where the Congress has been trying to consolidate the gains made in 2002 elections, the chief minister is at the receiving end of harsh whipping by right-wing groups like Bajrang Dal, VHP, besides BJP, who are accusing not just Azad but the Congress-led UPA Government at the Centre of having betrayed the entire nation. For Azad, dealing with the political fallout of the land controversy in Jammu and Kashmir regions has become a Catch-22 situation.

At the national level, BJP has already started whipping Congress at a time when it is struggling to deal with a likely electoral fallout of high inflation and the Indo-US nuclear deal. ■